THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

Can Eating and Sleeping Be Serving God?

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapter 5

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** Chapter 5
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 19 March 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Aim high, without despair

The class began with a short review of Chapters 1 to 4. Before the recording started, participants had shared their own examples of applying the middle path to a character trait, following last week's discussion of polarities.

The Rabbi gave a word of caution. Chapter 5 is extremely difficult to live by. The Rambam himself says at the end that a person who lives this way is not below a prophet. So we should neither get carried away nor despair. He recalled being told in yeshiva: aim to be the Rambam and you might become the Ben Ish Hai; aim lower and you will reach less. We may not get there, but we need to know where we are going. He added that this is not only ethics: it is codified as halacha in the Shulhan Arukh.

One goal for everything

The Rambam says a person should direct all the powers of his soul to one goal: **knowing God**, as far as a human being can. Every action, every movement, even rest, should lead to that goal, so that nothing he does is pointless.

The Rabbi connected this to *Shiviti HaShem lenegdi tamid*, "I have set HaShem before me always", which appears at the very start of the Shulhan Arukh. People inscribe it in their homes and at the top of siddur pages as a constant reminder.

A healthy body for a healthy soul

How does this work? We eat, drink, sleep, wake and rest in order to keep the body healthy. "You cannot have a healthy soul without a healthy body." But health is not the end. The purpose of a healthy body is that the soul and its faculties can pursue wisdom, acquire virtue and develop the intellect.

So when we eat, we should choose what is beneficial, not only what is tasty. If it happens to taste good, wonderful. If not, also fine.

The Rambam is blunt about the alternative. One who eats what is pleasant but unhealthy, only for the taste, is in his eyes acting like an animal. The Rabbi applied it to himself first: in the

Rambam's eyes, every glass of Coca-Cola is the act of an animal, because it is drunk only for pleasure. We are all mammals, he said, but we have a nefesh that lets us make responsible choices. Choosing the pleasurable over the beneficial means acting only as a mammal. Eating broccoli because the doctor said so, though it is not the tastiest thing, is using the intellect.

When pleasure is right

He asked the class: according to the Rambam, when may a person do something purely for pleasure? A participant answered: when a person feels low. That is the Rambam's answer too, and it follows from Chapter 4. Pleasure is medicine when the soul needs it: - A person who has lost his appetite is given tasty food, because he is at one extreme and needs bringing back. - A person who has fallen into melancholy can lift it by listening to music, playing instruments, walking in gardens and seeing beautiful buildings and art.

The Rabbi gave a second reason to enjoy art: to see the hand of God in it. He told how Rav Kook, visiting a London gallery, said that Rembrandt's paintings were painted with ruah hakodesh. So there are two reasons to go and see beautiful things: to appreciate God's world, or to restore a weary soul.

Two people, the same job

The Rabbi gave an example of how intention changes everything. Almost everyone has to work: "a person is born to toil." Two people go to the same job to earn money for their families. For the first, the goal ends with a good family life. There is nothing wrong with that, but it does not reach the level of Chapter 5. For the second, the money provides for home and family so that he and they can go on seeking to know HaKadosh Barukh Hu. The action is identical; the purpose makes them completely different people.

He also explained the Rambam's question from the laws of teshuvah: if the true reward is in the world to come, why does the Torah promise rain and crops? Because when a person does God's will, God gives him the physical needs that free his mind to keep serving. In the same way, the Rambam teaches that the messianic age will not change the world's nature. It will bring sovereignty for Israel in its land and freedom from want, so that people can pursue wisdom. "If you see work as an end in itself, you have a problem."

Medicine, mathematics and wisdom

The Rambam, speaking as a doctor, says medicine is a great path to knowing God, not to be compared with weaving or carpentry, because it teaches what is good and harmful for the body.

Some studies lead directly to knowing God, such as philosophy and theology. Others have no direct benefit but sharpen the mind: arithmetic, the study of conic sections, mechanics, geometry and hydraulics. They train us in proofs and in reasoning, which helps us understand more. The Rabbi noted the same idea in Rabbenu Saadiah Gaon, studied in his Monday class.

Speech, sleep and beauty

The principle applies to speech as well. A person with this goal will not speak about trivial things. That does not mean silence, the Rabbi said. Compliments and kind words have a purpose too. It means speaking with intention rather than by habit.

It applies to sleep: we sleep, about eight hours on the Rambam's recommendation, so that the body is rested to serve God. A tired body means a tired soul.

And it applies to luxury. The Rambam says such a person will not seek gold vessels or gold embroidery on his clothes, which the Rabbi rendered today as mansions and designer clothes. The exception, again, is medicine: a person low on confidence may dress well for a while to recover it.

The Gemara says a talmid hakham benefits from a pleasant home, a pleasant wife and pleasant furnishings. Why? Because a mind that works hard on difficult ideas grows tired, just as a labourer needs breaks. The sages would tell a joke when the students were tired. The Rabbi stressed the word *nice*, not extravagant. And in line with Chapter 4's preventive medicine: rest before you burn out, rather than needing weeks away afterwards.

Like a prophet

The Rambam concludes that this level is very high and reached by few, after much practice. One who weighs every action and word by whether it advances his character, his intellect and his knowledge of God, "I would not put him lower than a prophet."

This, he says, is the meaning of "love HaShem your God with all your soul": with every faculty of the soul. Shelomo said, "In all your ways know Him." And Hazal said it in a few words: **"Let all your deeds be for the sake of heaven."** The Rambam adds that only divine inspiration could put a whole chapter into so short a sentence.

The Rabbi's practical suggestion: try it once a day. Tonight, go to sleep not only because you are exhausted, but to have strength for tomorrow's work, which pays the bills, which frees the mind to think about God. The actions do not change. The intention does.

Further sources

The Rabbi read the parallel passage in Hilchot Deot, chapter 3. Living by the rules of medicine only for health is not the proper path; the body should be whole so the soul can know God. Even one's sleep, business and family life can then be service of God. He noted that the Shulhan Arukh, Orah Hayyim 231, records this as halacha. He also pointed to two passages in the Moreh Nevuchim, Part 3, chapters 8 and 51, including the parable of the king's palace and those at different distances from it.

Summary

- The one goal of every action is to know God as far as a person can.
- A healthy body is needed for a healthy soul, so we eat, drink and sleep for benefit, not only for pleasure.

- Pleasure is right as medicine, for a weary or low soul, and beauty can also show us the hand of God.
- The same job or meal can be mundane or holy, depending on its purpose.
- One who lives fully this way is not below a prophet: "Let all your deeds be for the sake of heaven."

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